

Blocking Storyboard

Every move, entrance, exit and light change — the picture and the line it lands on. Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi

HOW TO USE IT

- **One card = one moment.** Read top to bottom, in order, act by act and part by part. The text beside each picture is the verbatim line from the script where the move happens — nothing added.
- **The picture is the stage from above.** The audience sits at the bottom edge (↓). Everyone on stage in that moment is placed as a labelled dot. The move is drawn from a **solid dot** (where the character starts), along a **dashed arrow**, to a **hollow ring** (where they end). A **burst** marks a sudden event — the veil, the revolver, the gunshot.
- **Doors are labelled on the frame** — the gaps in the wall. Entrances and exits run to and from them, and each tag names *which way*: *enters · door at back · USC, EXIT · unhurried, out of the office · SL, to the wings · SR, leaves toward the house · downstage*.
- **The light is named on every card** — the badge top-right, and the floor is tinted to match the cue. The set is drawn per act: the chair-circle (One), the two-level platform with shower column, piano and pegs (Two), the fountain with the Manager's table and its bare bulb (Three). □ is the Boy-chair, ◇ the Child-bundle.

ORIENTATION — WHICH WAY IS WHICH

The audience sits at the foot of every map (**downstage**, DS); the back wall is the top (**upstage**, US). Because the actors face the house, the actor's right — **stage-right (SR)** — is the *left* of the page, and **stage-left (SL)** is the right. So *USC* = upstage centre (the door at back), *SL* = the prompt side here (office, dressing rooms), *SR* = the opposite wing. Every entrance and exit names its direction.

THE LIGHT CUES

HALF-DARK	the bare work-light of an empty house, before the play
WORK LIGHT	full white rehearsal light
REHEARSAL	the light brought down for “Mixing It Up”
AMBER WASH	the tenuous light of the Six
DEEP RED	as they cross off to the office
SHOWER	the tight overhead column on one figure
CURTAIN ↓ / ↑	the curtain falls / rises
FOUNTAIN + BULB	only the fountain glow and the bare bulb
BLACKOUT	full dark — the gunshot
LIGHTS SNAP UP	the snap back after the shot

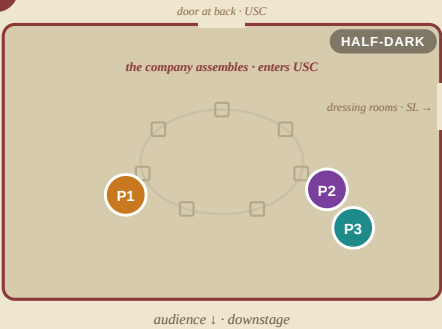
WHO IS WHO

F Father	M Mother	SD Step-Daughter	S Son	MG Manager	P1 Player 1
P2 Player 2	P3 Player 3	MP Madame Pace	BOY Boy-chair	CH Child-bundle	

Act One — The Family

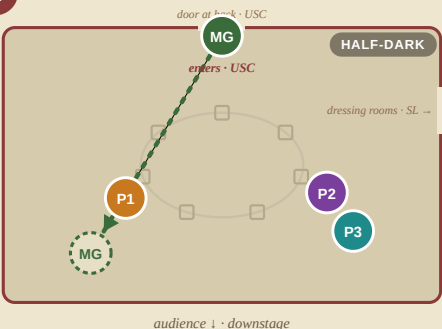
PART I — THE REHEARSAL

1



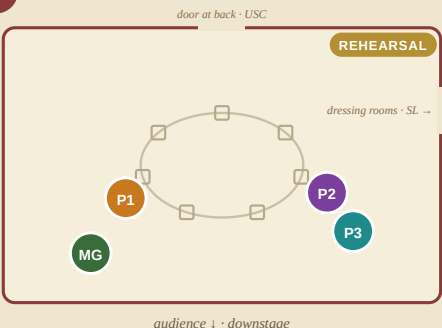
[The Actors and Actresses of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. Some move off towards their dressing rooms. The Prompter, the “book” under his arm, waits for the Manager].

2



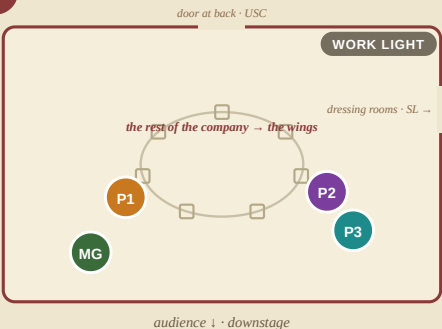
[Finally, the Manager enters with the precise weariness of a man who has managed the Village Players too long; he goes to his table].

3



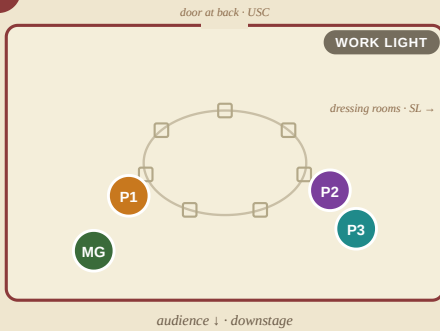
THE MANAGER *[to the Property Man].* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening. **PLAYER 2** *[as Property Man].* Yes, sir. At once. *[A light comes down on to the stage].*

4



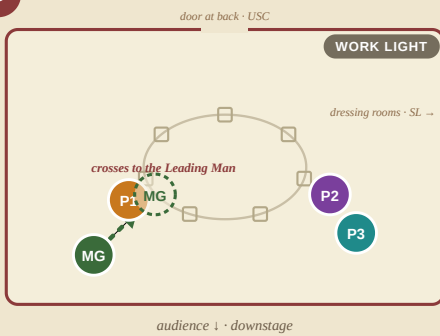
THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands].* Come along! Second act of “Mixing It Up” — and play it as if you wanted the public back for the third. *[The Actors go to the wings, all except the three who begin the rehearsal].*

5



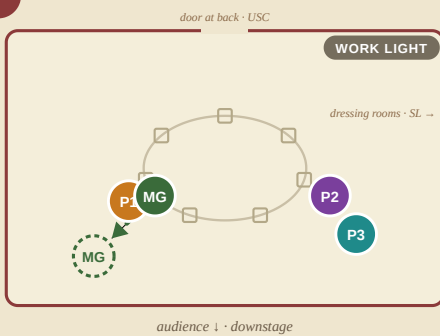
PLAYER 1 [*as Leading Man*]. Excuse me, but must I absolutely wear a cook's cap? It's ridiculous. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years.

6



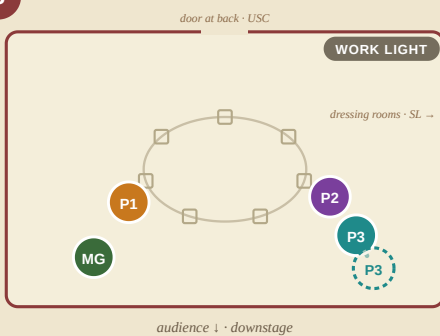
THE MANAGER [*jumping up in a rage, crossing to the Leading Man*]. Ridiculous? Is it my fault if France won't send us any more good comedies?

7



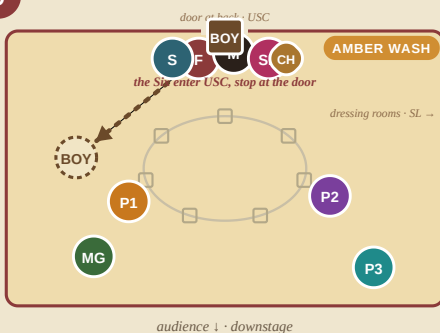
THE MANAGER. Wouldn't we all, sir. But let's get on with it. [*he goes back to his table*]

8



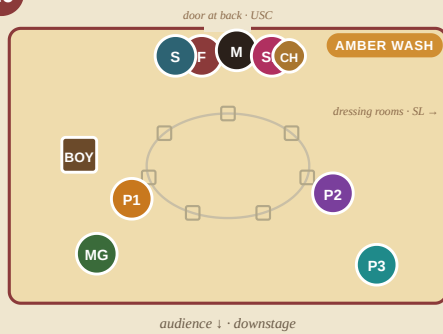
PLAYER 3 [*as Prompter, getting into the box*]. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

9



[*The white working lights soften to a warm amber. The Door-keeper carries on the Boy-chair and sets it at the edge of the stage; the four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — enter and stop by the door at back, the Step-Daughter carrying the Child-bundle*].

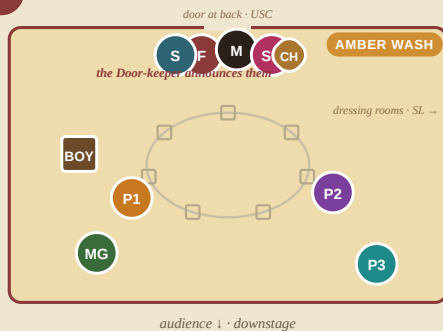
10



[A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them. It will disappear when they come forward].

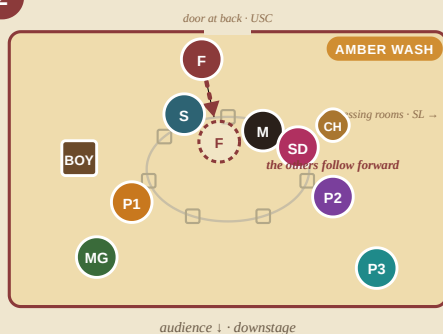
PART II — THE INTERRUPTION

1



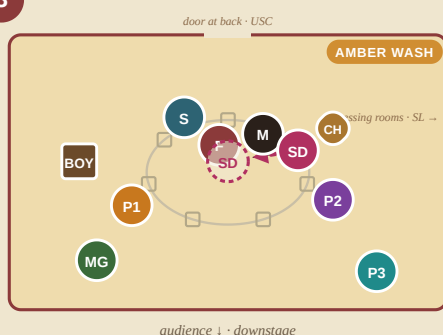
PLAYER 1 [as Door-keeper, cap in hand]. Excuse me, sir — these people are asking for you; they insist on coming in. **THE MANAGER** [rudely]. I am rehearsing — no one is allowed in during rehearsals!

2



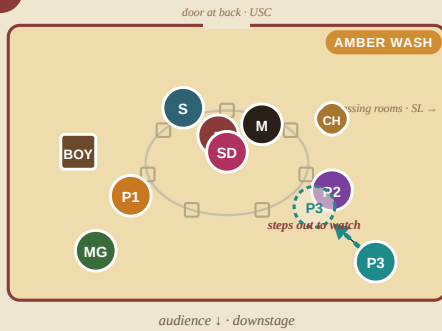
THE FATHER [coming forward, the others following, embarrassed]. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

3



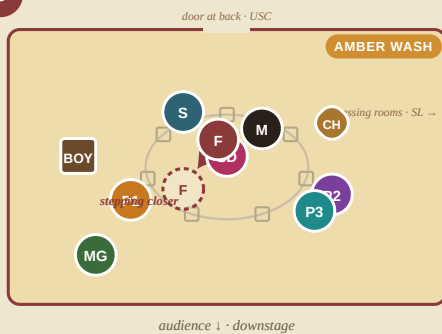
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [stepping in front of the Father, taking the line]. So much the better, sir. You can put us on tonight.

4



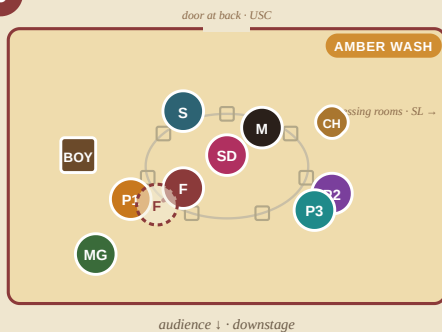
PLAYER 3 *[coming forward from the others]*. Oh — do you hear that?

5



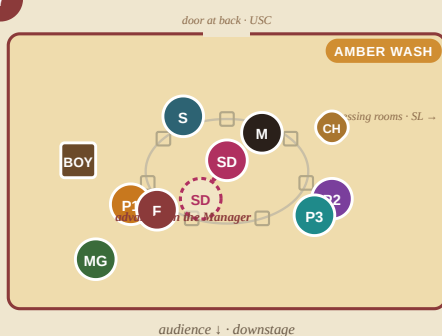
THE FATHER *[stepping closer, voice softening]*. You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

6



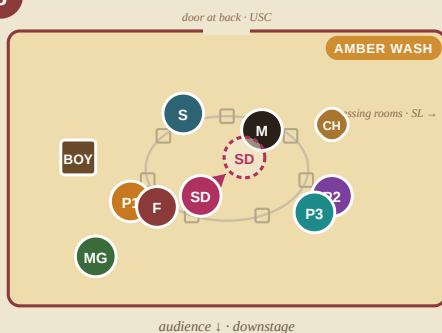
THE MANAGER. But what do you want here, all of you? **THE FATHER**. We want to live. **THE MANAGER**. For Eternity? **THE FATHER**. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

7



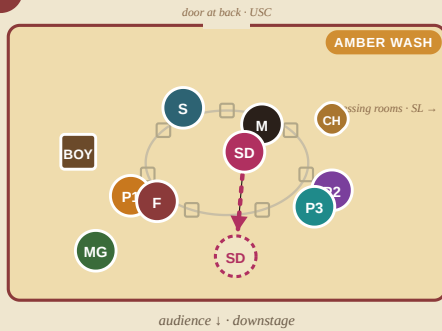
THE FATHER *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me. Aren't you used to seeing the characters an author creates spring to life? **THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[advances towards the Manager, eyes level]*. We are really six most interesting characters, sir — side-tracked, however.

8



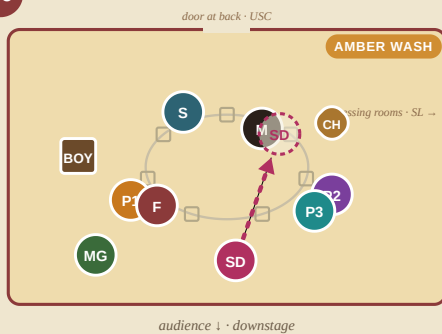
THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[crossing behind the Father; a hand on his shoulder, left one beat too long, then withdrawn]*. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*.

9



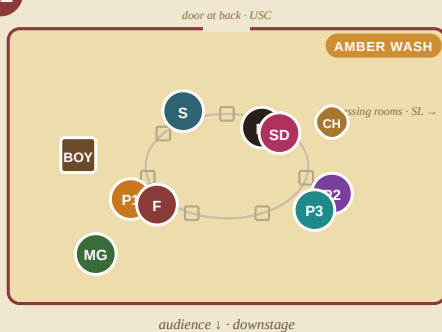
THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. [*Sings and dances Valentine*].

10



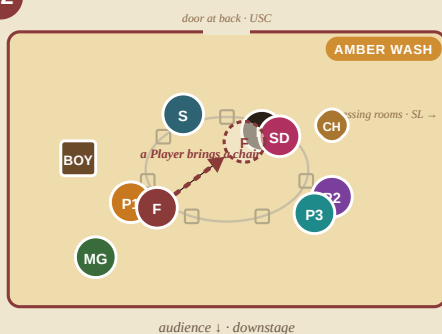
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*goes to the Mother and embraces her*]. Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling...

11



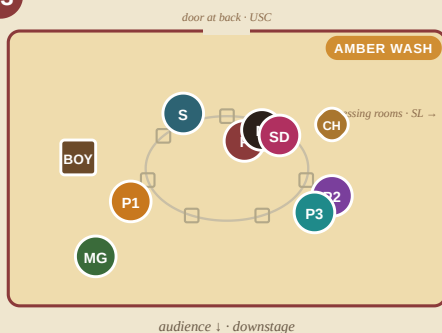
THE MOTHER [*one arm tightening round the Child-bundle*]. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... [*she grows faint*] Oh God!

12



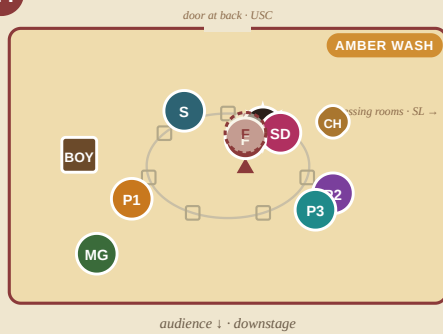
THE FATHER [*coming forward to support her; an Actor brings a chair*]. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

13



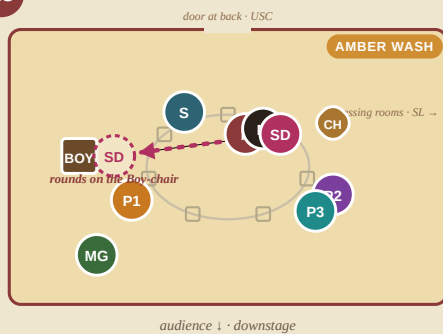
THE MOTHER [*rising and covering her face with her hands*]. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

14



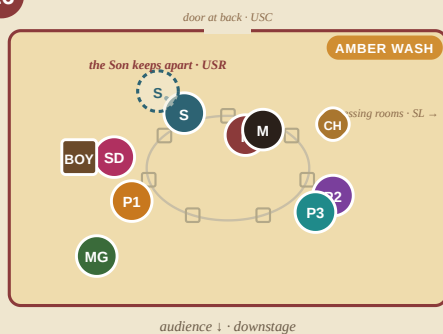
THE FATHER [*raising her veil*]. Let them see you!

15



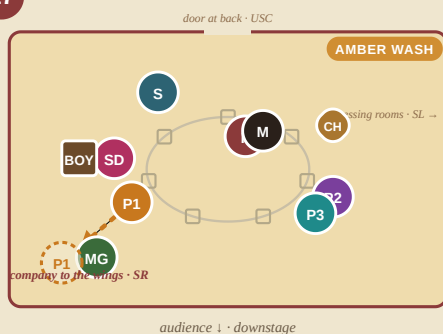
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him*]. He was always full of affection and kindness for you.

16



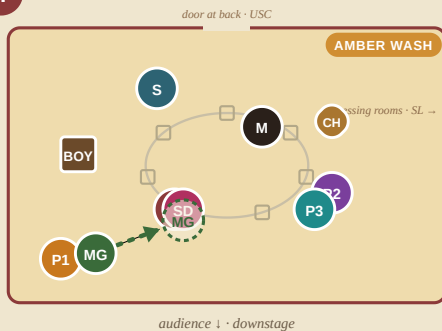
THE SON [*hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Leave me alone. I don't come into this. **THE FATHER**. What? You don't come into this?

17



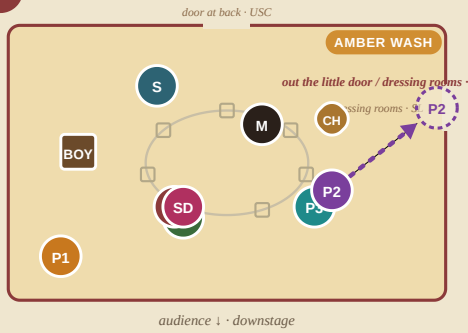
PLAYER 1 [*as Leading Man, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the Mother, and the rest does not arrive*]. What a spectacle. What an absolute...

1



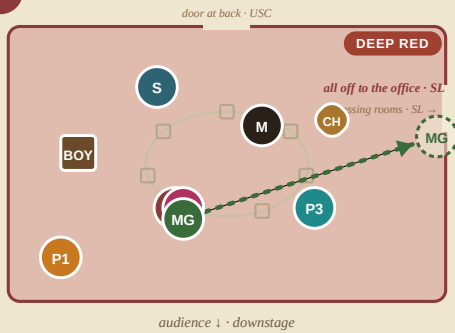
THE MANAGER [*moves away, then turning to the Actors*]. Yes, yes. Come on! Be punctual, please!

5



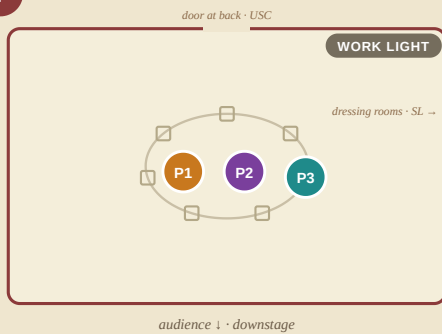
[Thus talking, the Actors leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back, others retiring to their dressing-rooms].

6



THE MANAGER [hooked; leading the Father and the Six off to his office]. Come with me to my office. In a quarter of an hour, all back here again. [They cross the stage and go off].

7



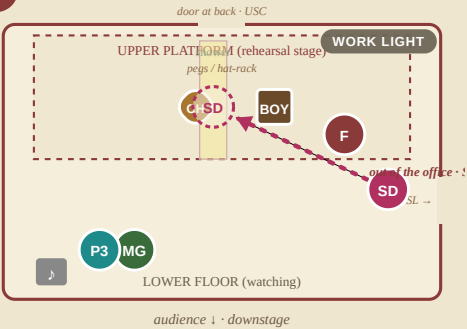
PLAYER 1 [as Leading Man]. Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

PLAYER 2 [as Leading Lady]. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed. **PLAYER 3**. Perhaps there is a play.

Act Two — The Theatre

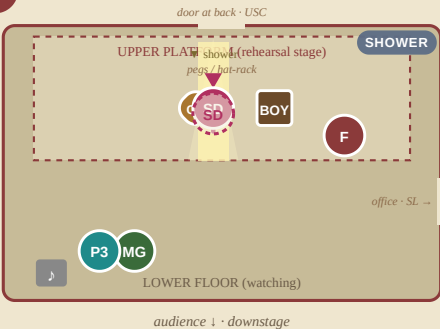
PART I — THE SETUP

1



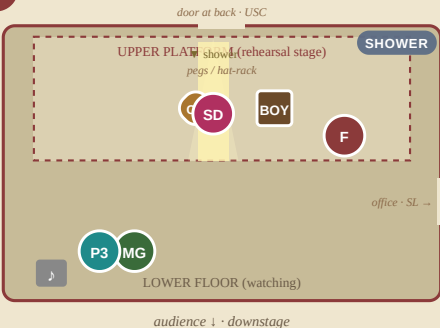
THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[comes out of the Manager's office carrying the Child-bundle and dragging the Boy-chair, and cries]:* Come on, Rosetta, let's run!

2



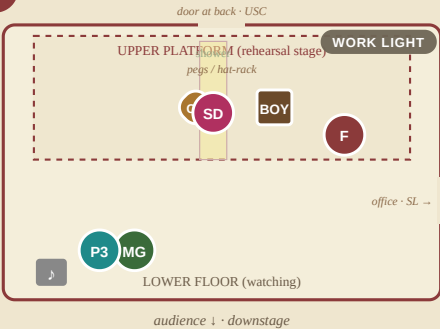
[She drags the Boy-chair a little behind her and leaves it leaning. The stage darkens; the shower — a tight vertical column of light — falls on the Step-Daughter only. The pianist begins Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, and she kneels with the Child-bundle].

3



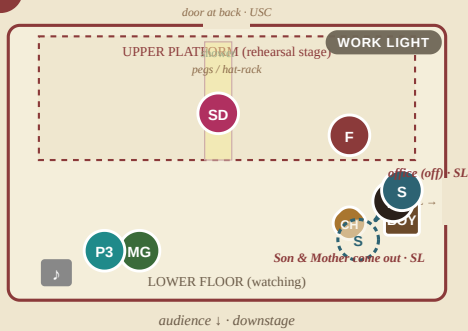
[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver. She holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket].

4



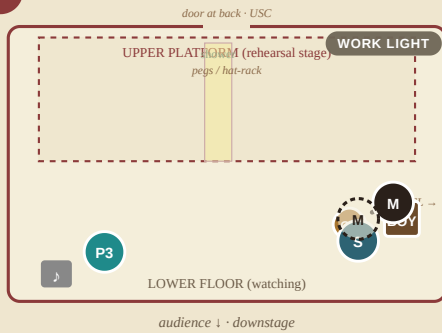
[The piano dies on her last word. The shower releases; the working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair].

5



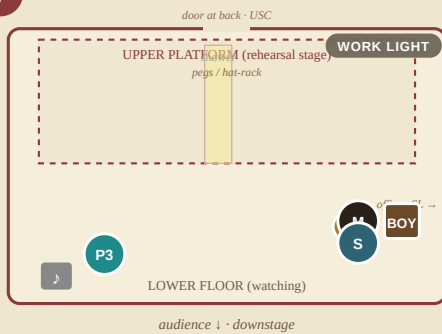
[The Father, Manager and Step-Daughter go back into the office (off); at the same time the Son, followed by the Mother, comes out].

6



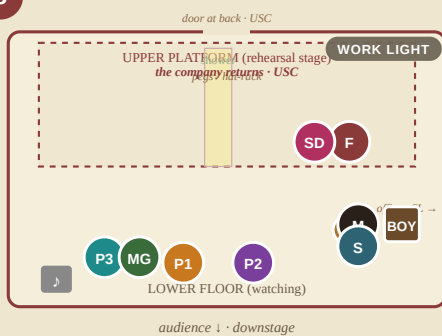
THE MOTHER *[rises; one step toward the Son]. My son — [the Son turns away before the word is finished; she stops].*

7



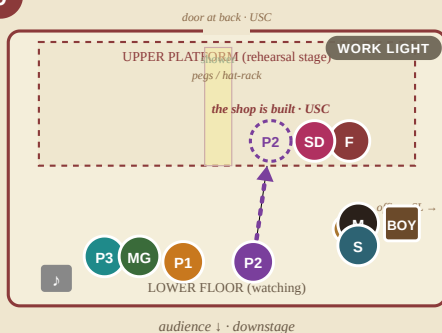
THE SON *[half to himself, eyes on the floor]. And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it.*

8



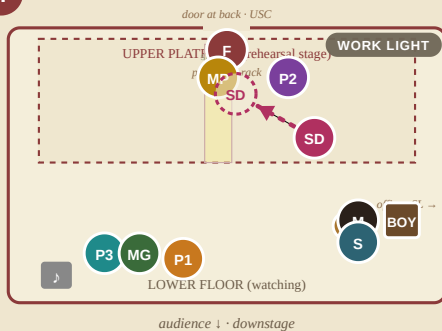
[The stage call-bells ring. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back the company returns; the Manager comes out of his office with the Father and the Step-Daughter].

9



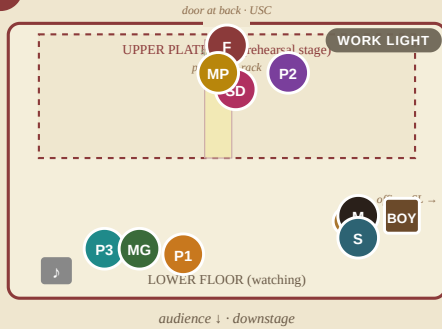
THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to manage? **PLAYER 2** *[as Property Man, setting the shop]. That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.*

1



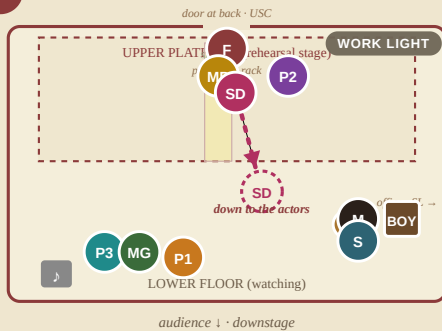
THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[turning towards her, running over]*. There she is! There she is!

5



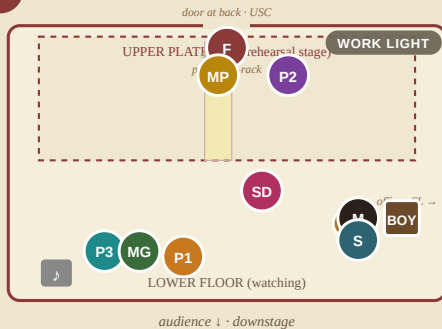
[Madame Pace places one hand under the Step-Daughter's chin to raise her head]. **MADAME PACE**. Good morning, good morning, sir! Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg.

6



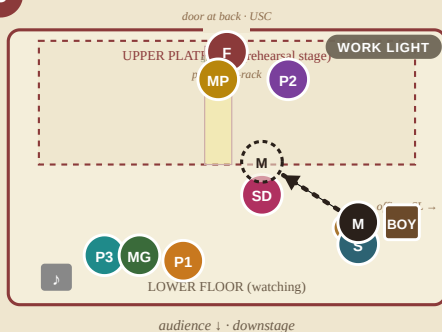
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [leaving Madame Pace and advancing towards the actors]. Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about?

7



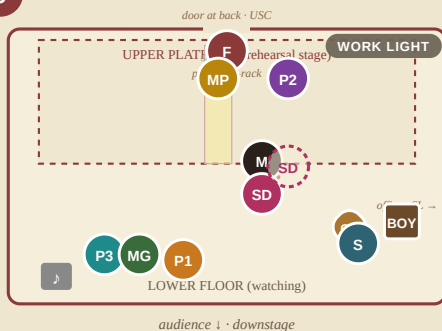
MADAME PACE [the comedy curdling]. Not so old, my dear. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir?

8



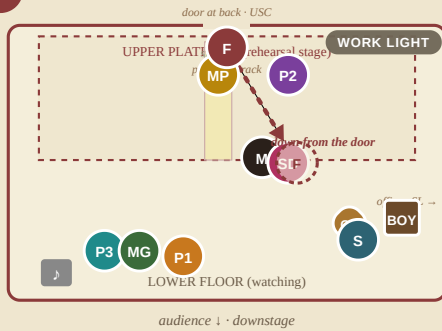
THE MOTHER [jumping up amid the consternation of the actors — the voice she has not used for years]. You old devil! You murderess!

9



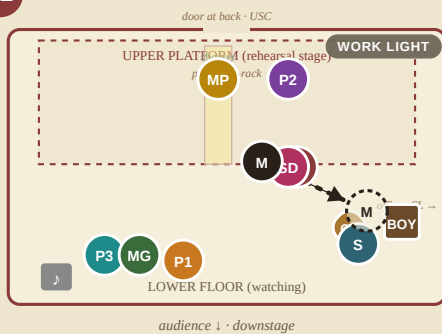
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [running over to calm her Mother]. Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

10



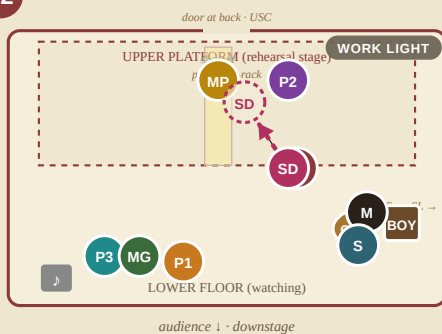
THE FATHER [going to her also, the body beginning to give him away]. Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

11



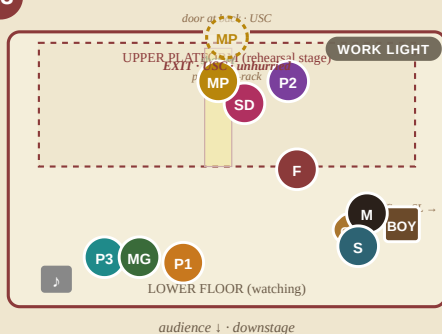
THE MANAGER [turning to the Mother and leading her to her chair]. Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene.

12



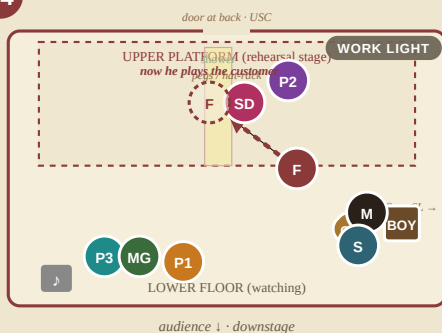
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [coming forward again, turns to Madame Pace]. Come on, Madame, come on!

13



MADAME PACE [pausing at the door, the smile calm now, almost tender]. There is always the next silk. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. Don't you forget the name. [Exits. Not furious. Unhurried].

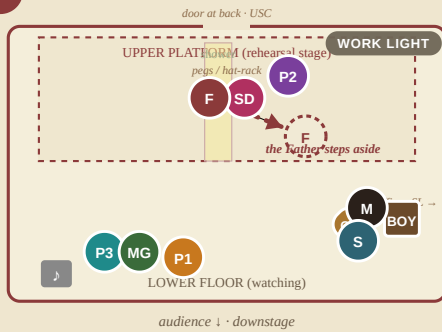
14



THE FATHER [coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was]. Good afternoon, Miss.

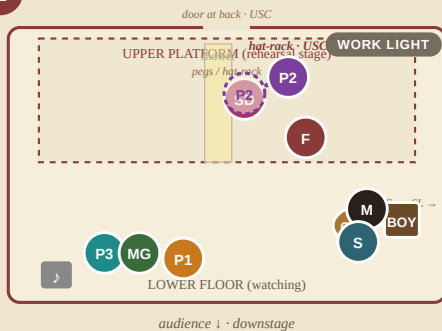
PART III — THE SUBSTITUTION

1



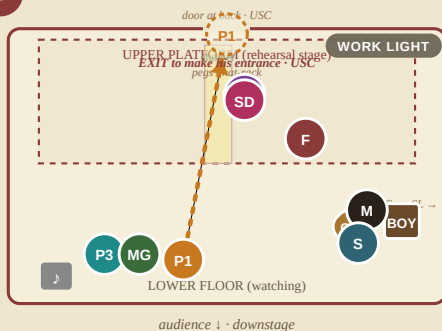
THE MANAGER *[to the company]*. Be quiet, please, and watch — you'll learn something. *[Stand aside and let me see the action]*. **THE FATHER** *[stepping aside to watch his own scene replayed]*.

2



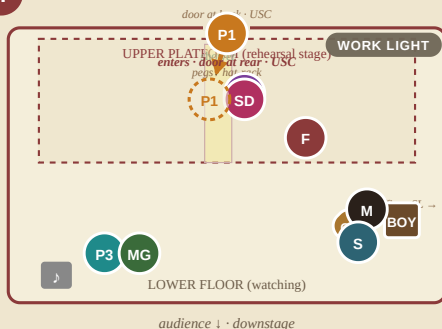
PLAYER 2 *[as Leading Lady; goes over to the hat-rack and puts her hat on, to play the Step-Daughter]*. One minute. I want to put my hat on again.

3



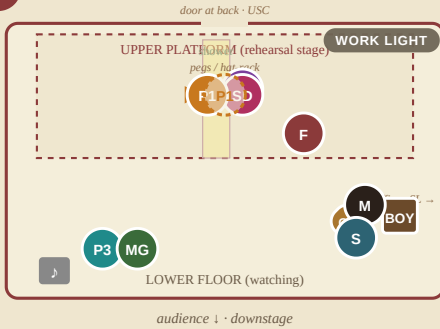
PLAYER 1 *[as Leading Man]*. Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. *[Exit to make his entrance]*.

4



[The door at rear opens and the Leading Man enters with the lively manner of an old gallant]. **PLAYER 1** *[as Leading Man]*. Good afternoon, Miss.

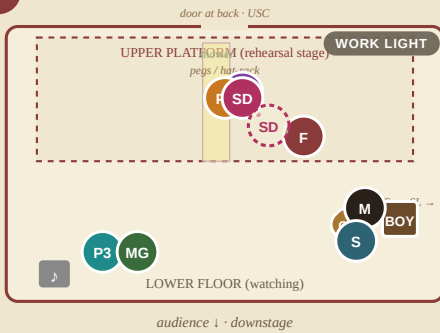
5



PLAYER 1 [*as Leading Man, a step closer, practised gallantry*].

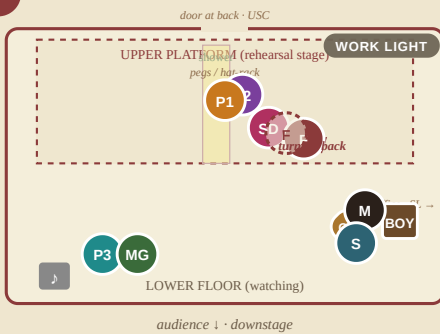
Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat.

6



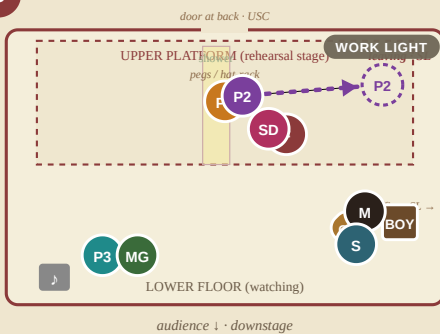
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*unable to keep still; advancing toward the actors*]. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

7



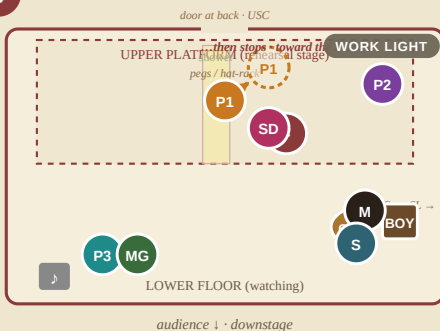
THE FATHER [*turning back, quietly*]. Yes. He said "Oh."

8



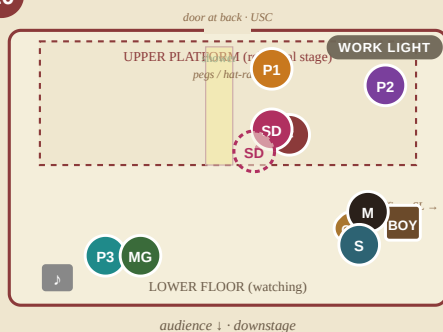
PLAYER 2 [*the diva's posture going from offended to leaving*]. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman.

9



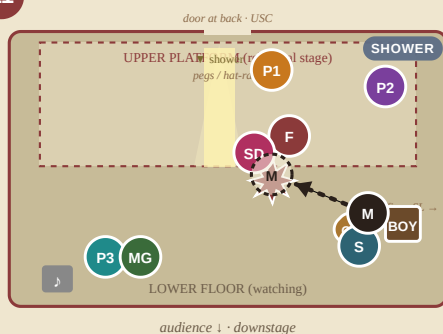
PLAYER 1 [*as Leading Man; two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops*]. Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

10



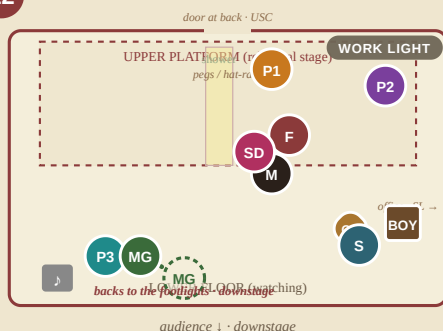
THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I can hear it still in my ears — that cry. You may put me on as you like, provided I have that cry. **THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Cry out, mother. *Cry out as you did then!*

11



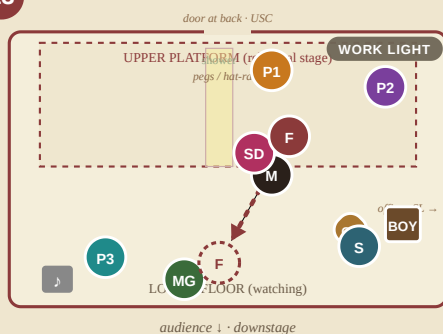
THE MOTHER [*coming forward to separate them; the shower falls on her*]. No! My daughter, my daughter! You brute! She is my daughter!

12



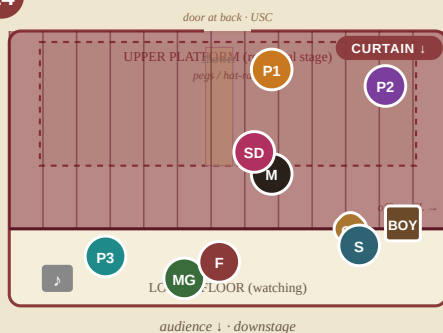
THE MANAGER [*walking backwards towards the footlights — the way a satisfied audience member would*]. Fine. Fine! And then we have the curtain there.

13



THE FATHER [*going towards him excitedly*]. Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

14

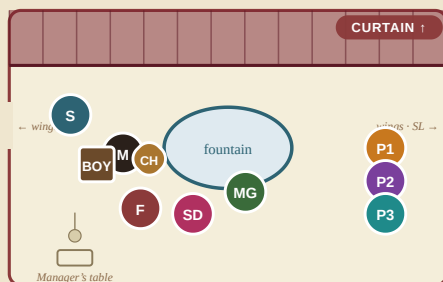


THE MANAGER. Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain! [*the Machinist lets the curtain down in earnest — the act ends on the curtain's fall*].

Act Three — The Question

PART I — THE TRAP

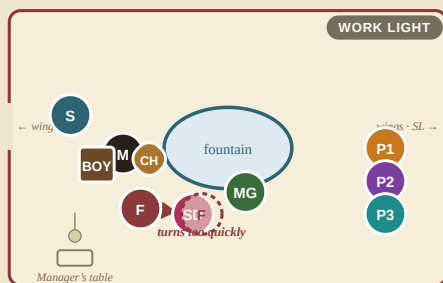
1



audience ↓ · downstage

[Curtain up. The two-level set is struck; the stage is bare but for a single fountain basin, centre. The family sit stage-right — the Mother with the Child-bundle in her lap and the Boy-chair against her knee, the Son apart, the Father and Step-Daughter at the right front; the company sit stage-left; the Manager stands centre]. **THE MANAGER.** Ah yes: the second act!

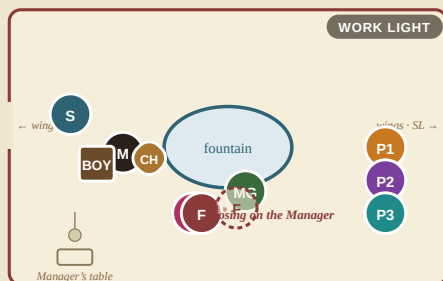
2



audience ↓ · downstage

PLAYER 2 [as *Leading Lady*]. The audience needs to know which room we are in. **THE FATHER** [the word lands physically — he turns too quickly]. The illusion — for Heaven's sake, don't say illusion. Don't use that word.

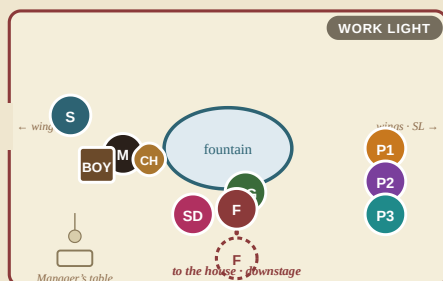
3



audience ↓ · downstage

THE FATHER [a step or two nearer the Manager; then, slowly, turning out toward the house]. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own.

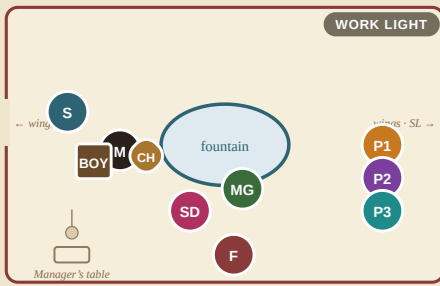
4



audience ↓ · downstage

THE FATHER [turning full out to the house; a pause long enough to feel]. Can you tell me who you are?

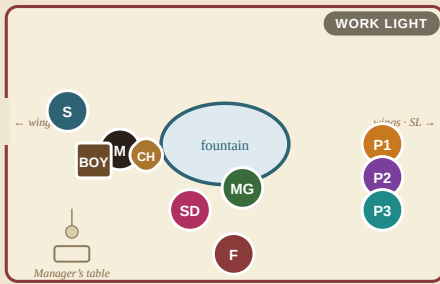
5



audience ↓ · downstage

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*level, never raised — colder than the philosophy*]. His reality. He always knew exactly where to find me.

6

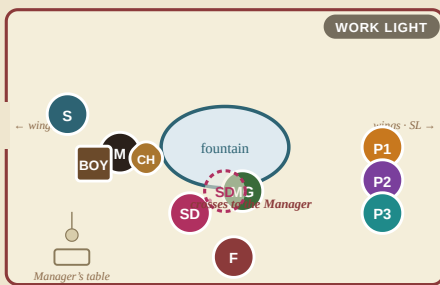


audience ↓ · downstage

THE MANAGER. Then you'll be saying you are more true and real than I am? **THE FATHER** [*the greatest seriousness — the cry breaks, then the body goes still*]. But of course. Without doubt.

PART II — THE REFUSAL

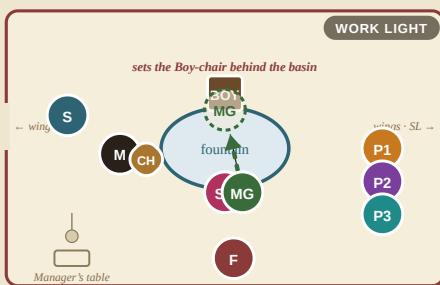
1



audience ↓ · downstage

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*goes close to the Manager, as if in confidence*]. In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of disgust for the ordinary theatre.

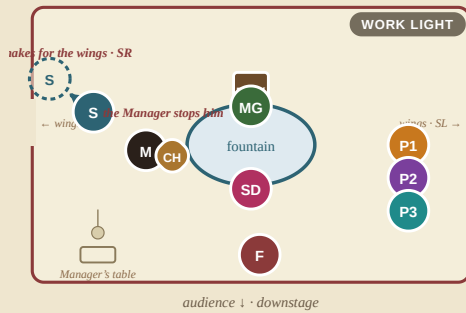
2



audience ↓ · downstage

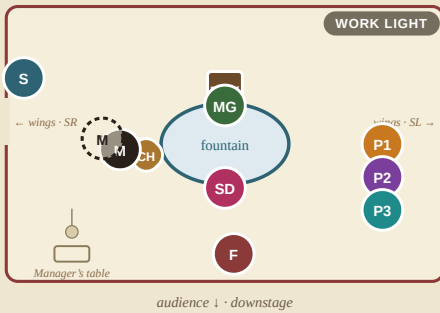
THE MANAGER [*he stands; he picks up the Boy-chair himself and walks it across the stage, and places it behind the fountain basin — the pivot of his arc*].

3



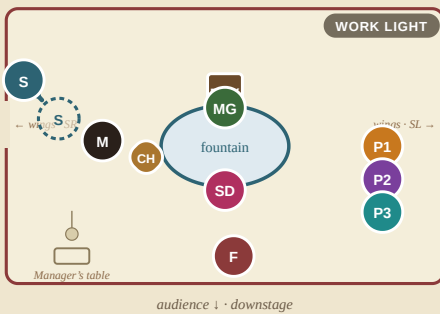
THE SON *[jumping up]*. Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. *[begins to move away]* **THE MANAGER** *[at once stopping him]*. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

4



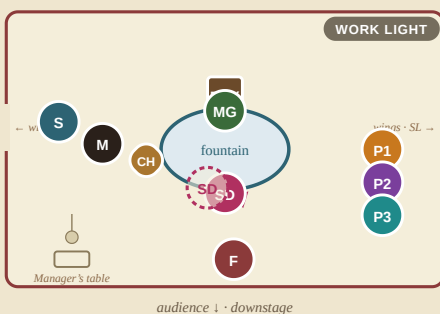
THE MOTHER *[gets up, alarmed and terrified that he is really about to go, and instinctively lifts her arms]*. *[She does not reach him]*.

5



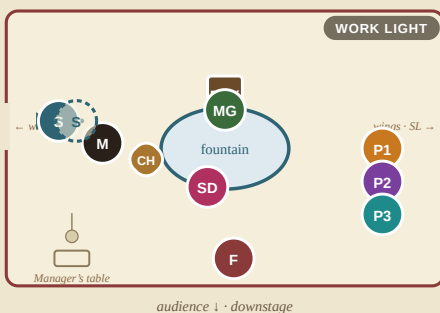
THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[calmly — she knows him]*. Don't bother to stop him. He won't go. **THE SON**. I will act nothing at all. I've said so from the very beginning.

6



THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[going over to the Manager, and putting down his arm]*. Allow me? Well — go on then. Go away.

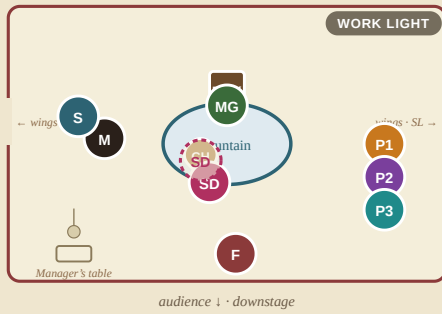
7



THE SON *[trapped now, and knowing it]*. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat — I act nothing. **THE FATHER**. You can force him, sir. **THE FATHER**. I can.

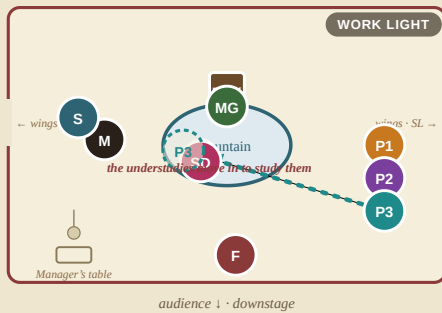
PART III — THE FOUNTAIN

1



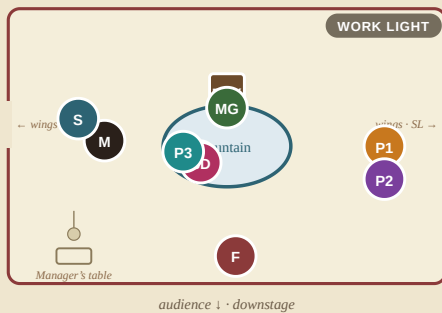
THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Wait — first of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... *[lifts the Child-bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it toward the fountain].*

2



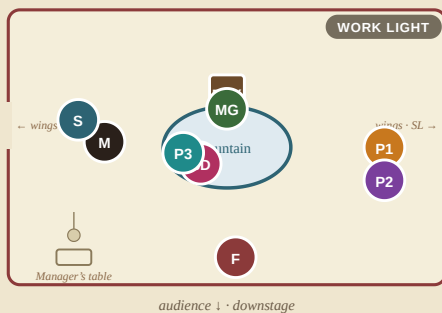
[The Second Lady Lead and the Juvenile Lead separate themselves from the group of Actors — one watches the Mother attentively, the other studies the movements of the Son he will have to play].

3



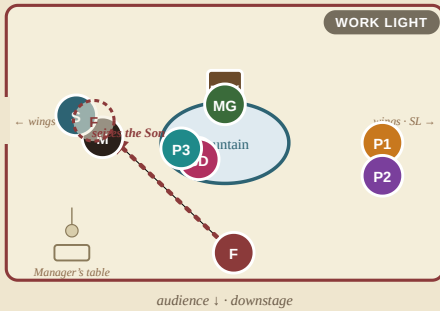
THE SON *[the cry he has held the whole production — surprising himself]*. Yes — but haven't you yet perceived that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror that throws our likeness back at us with a horrible grimace?

4



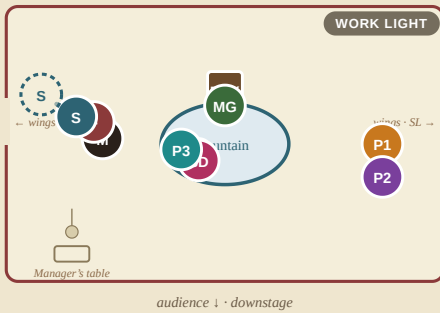
THE MOTHER. Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me — all of it. *[a hand at her chest]*

5



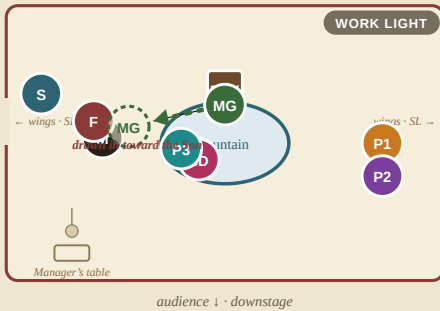
THE FATHER *[going to the Son in a great rage, taking hold of him].*
You'll do this for your mother, do you understand? You've got to obey,
do you hear?

6



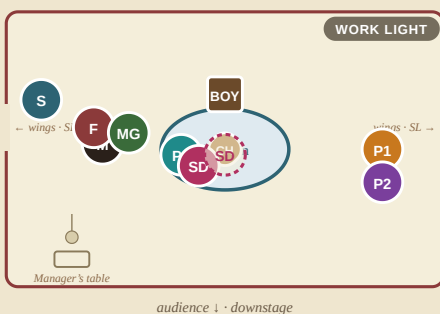
THE SON *[taking hold of the Father; then the voice cracks and they separate].* No! No! And for God's sake stop it! What does it mean —
this madness you've got?

7



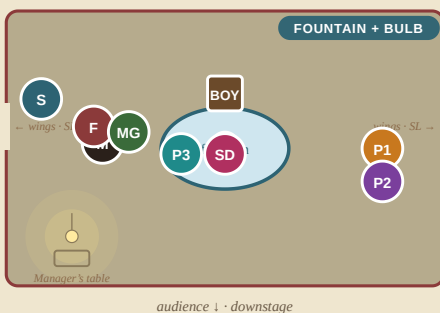
THE MANAGER *[coming closer to the Son, interested by his extraordinary reserve].* Well, well... walking in the garden...

8



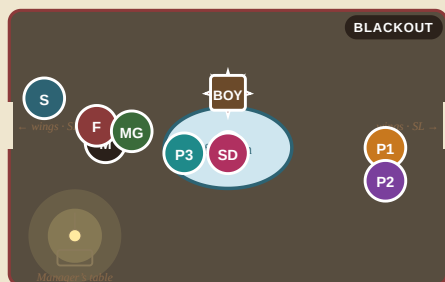
THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it; the basin's walls hide the action from view].*

9



THE SON *[his one continuous sentence; the stage lights drop, breath by breath, until only the fountain and the bare bulb over the Manager's table remain — the Boy-chair silhouetted behind the basin].* There in the fountain...

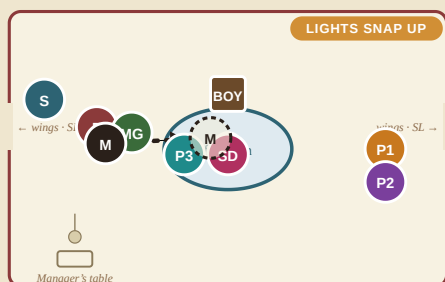
10



audience ↓ · downstage

[Full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the Boy-chair is].

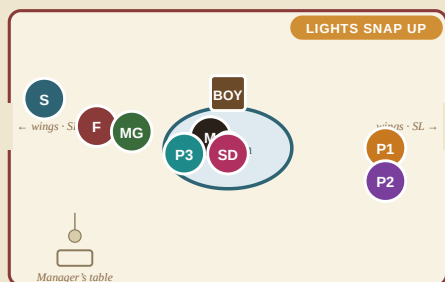
11



audience ↓ · downstage

THE MOTHER [she does not cry out at once — she reaches first for the Child-bundle in the basin, then the Boy-chair behind it; her arms cannot hold both, the veil still down]. My son! My son!

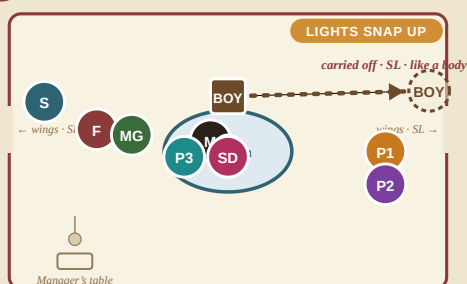
12



audience ↓ · downstage

TWO PLAYERS. He's dead! dead! **THE OTHER PLAYERS.** No, no — it's only make-believe, only pretence! **THE FATHER** [with a terrible cry]. Pretence? Reality, sir — reality!

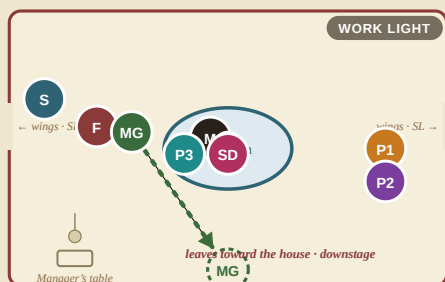
13



audience ↓ · downstage

[The Players lift up the Boy-chair and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible].

14



audience ↓ · downstage

THE MANAGER [a look at the place where the Boy-chair stood, then he turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre]. Pretence? Reality? ... To hell with it all.